

Keep tension when it preserves choices

Positional Judgment

THE IDEA

Pawn or piece tension gives each side the option to capture. Releasing it can clarify the position but also free the opponent. Maintain tension when your position benefits from flexibility and no tactical reason forces a decision.

WORKED EXAMPLE

Two central pawns attack one another. Capturing may open a file for the opponent's rook; advancing may close your own bishop; waiting may preserve both options. Calculate each transformation before choosing.

TRY IT BEFORE READING ON

When should you resolve tension immediately?

ANSWER AND REASONING

When a favorable tactic exists, the opponent threatens to exploit it, or the resulting structure clearly serves your plan. 'Keep tension' is not a reason to ignore a forcing move.

TAKE THIS INTO YOUR NEXT GAME

Value the options tension preserves, then choose the best transformation.